Rupa. Their Bravo and Charlie Company positions were now tested amidst the scramble by the last remnants of 48 Brigade to get out of harm's way. The Chinese, having created panic with their random machine gun fire, now started sending small jitter parties to dislodge the Gorkhas. Given the number of troops available to the Chinese, it is highly unlikely that they would have assaulted the Gorkha positions in strength. As darkness gave way to light on 20 November, both these positions were deserted as the Gorkhas broke contact and pulled back. Chaku was littered with the dead and the dying. 6/8 GR alone had lost 147 men who were either killed, captured or were otherwise unaccounted for.

Around this time, having spent the previous day wandering around in circles, 1 Madras found itself just above the Tenga Bridge. From its position, the entire valley looked abandoned, so Lieutenant Colonel Chandran decided to take the road to Chaku. As the battalion emerged from the cover of the jungle, it came under heavy machine gun and mortar fire from the Chinese who were waiting for them. The 2IC, Major W. N. C. Hensman was killed along with another seven men from the Intelligence Section. Chandran along with 3 officers, 5 JCOs and 187 other ranks plus two non-combatants surrendered to the Chinese and were taken prisoner. In addition, twenty-one other ranks were captured from the company deployed at Dirang Dzong while another thirty-seven men remained missing, believed killed. Those who escaped made their way back to Assam through the dense jungles in small, scattered parties.

At 7 a.m. on 20 November, HQ 48 Brigade reached the foothills. Like 7, 62 and 65 Brigade, it had ceased to exist as a fighting formation. The two battalions of 67 Brigade, sent in to defend Bomdila, were also wiped out. The rout of 4 Infantry Division was absolute. With 11 Brigade having disintegrated earlier in the Walong Sector on 16 November itself, NEFA had fallen. It is highly unlikely that any army in the annals of military history had folded so easily in the face of an enemy who was not particularly numerically superior. Let down time and again by its senior officers, the Indian Army and the people of Assam now lay at the mercy of a handful of Chinese.

HQ IV CORPS (TEZPUR)

Even in their wildest dreams, the Chinese commanders could not have expected the Indians to fold in all the three locations—Se-la, Dirang Dzong